

Mobile Watch

A look at the business of iPhone apps and the nearly indestructible phone from Nokia

Wikipedia: Behind the pages

How Wikipedia works? The technology behind one of the largest web sites on the internet

Browsers ahoy

Filled with activity in the browser industry, internet users have increased options to choose from. We look at the latest happenings with Opera, Safari and more

Opera Unite

Browsers have witnessed significant changes in recent times. Whether it's a boost in speed or some added functionality, browser developers are pulling out all the stops to come up with the most superior product. Opera developers also came out with their bid – Unite, a technology that they claim will turn a computer running the Opera browser into a web server. Contrary to the traditional client-server approach, Opera claims to place the user in control of his / her own data, by allowing users to connect directly to their friends for sharing files and also allowing several other activities such as networking and more. But who really wants so much control? More importantly, does anyone care? People are very comfortable having hundreds of photos hosted on third party servers. Most average users won't even understand the difference between sharing content from hosted services and their own hard drive. If Opera wants to succeed with Unite, it'll have to move past flogging this concept and

playing on users inherent fears about privacy and control. Besides, many online bloggers have pointed out that given the centralised routing of data, you eventually do end up relying on Opera proxy servers, making this an indirect approach after all.

We seriously doubt all the hype that Unite will reinvent the web. Services such as Windows Live Sync and Dropbox have been allowing file-sharing and similar services for a long time, albeit without browser integration. In fact, many of the little services offered by Opera Unite are already being offered by different players independently. All Opera is doing is consolidating all of them under its browser's umbrella – hardly ground breaking.

These services include file sharing, photo sharing, note sharing, remote media player, a chat room service and a web server. The first two are too familiar. The Fridge is a service that seems fun at first,

but makes you wonder if it is really useful. Opera describes it as "A fun place for people to leave notes on your computer." It is the virtual equivalent of leaving notes on the refrigerator door. Except on your virtual fridge, it's not only you but a whole lot of your contacts online that can leave you notes. All they have to know is the unique URL that gets created, which goes something like <http://compname.username.operaunite.com/fridge/>.

The Media Player service allows you to access your complete home music library from wherever you are, without having to upload it. The web server allows you to host web sites off your PC. To try out

Unite, head over to the Opera web site and download the latest alpha build. In the left panel, you will find the Unite button which gives you access to these services. You will need to register an account with Opera, if you don't already have one.

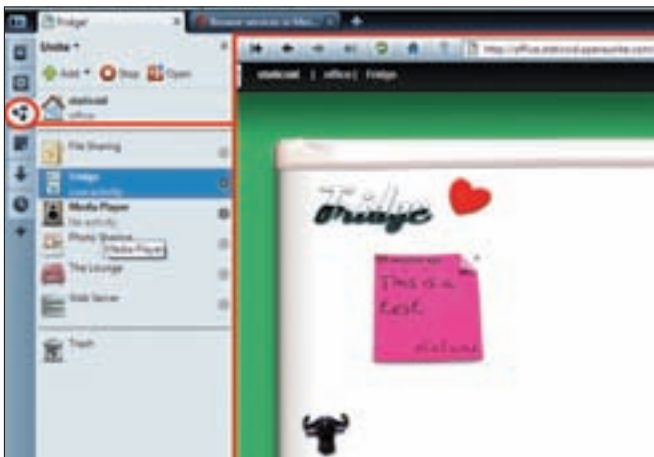
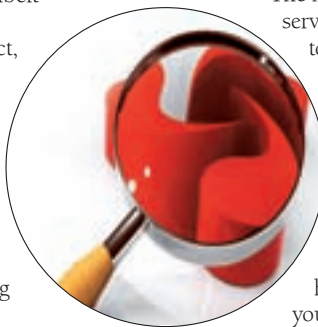
Opera is also offering the API to developers to create their own Unite services. So far, there are no new services added to the Unite repertoire. The bottom line is that Opera makes one of the most stable, fast and light browsers in the market. They should probably focus on that core strength instead of tangential experiments.

Safari 4

Yes, we know it released at the beginning of June but it's never too late to take a crack at something that claims to be the "World's fastest browser". Also, the recent update (4.0.2) to the browser's Java engine released

mid-July, is supposed to make it stable, and so, worthy of being pitted against fellow contenders in the browser world. Whether it lives up to Apple's ambitious claim, we shall see later; for now let's look at the user experience that the browser provides and the improvements it offers over the previous release. Even with a cursory glance, you'll see the similarity with Chrome. In particular, the page control and settings buttons at the top right corner of the screen. The drop down menus that they produce are almost identical. So is the position of the forward / back navigation button as well as the refresh button. The only difference in the navigation bar is that the search field is independent of the Address Bar, while in Chrome they're clubbed into one.

The visual effects are spectacular, as with any Apple product. The home screen which shows the most visited sites or favourites, looks stunning. It's a change from the older concept of having the most recently visited sites. But navigating from here seems sluggish when compared to Opera or Firefox (when running on a Windows 7 system). The start page is fully customisable, in terms of sites you want displayed, size of the panes and arrangement on screen. Going into the edit option will bring up a pinning tack icon that makes the site a permanent one, while the X will get rid of it. Also, it appears Apple's affinity for coverflow continues. The feature has now been ported into Safari to let users browse through history using the coverflow style. So web pages in your browser history will be smoothly gliding past at your will. Speaking of history, if you



Opera Unite showing the Fridge service